BREAK INTO CYBERSECURITY

The Complete Beginner's Course & Learning Guide

2026 Edition

Sr. Staff Cybersecurity Professional · 20+ Years in Industry
CISM · CISA · CSA · CAD · CIS-VR · Cybersecurity Instructor & Mentor
By Bon Capuyan — Connect on LinkedIn

200+	20+	$300K+	17
Students Mentored	Years in Cybersecurity	Current Annual Salary	Core Learning Topics

In 8 weeks, go from zero cybersecurity experience to Security+ certified and lab-proven — with a portfolio and résumé ready to start applying for entry-level IT and cybersecurity-adjacent roles. No degree required, no need to quit your job, and for less than 5% of what top bootcamps charge.

Table of Contents

1. About This Course 3
    1.1 Key Course Information and End Goals 3
2. The Data: What Actually Determines Who Succeeds 9
    2.1 Paid vs. Corporate-Sponsored Success Rates 9
    2.2 The 4 Success Factors 9
    2.3 The 4 Failure Modes 10
3. Your Mentor's Journey: 2002–2025 11
4. The Certification Roadmap 12
    4.1 The CompTIA Pathway 12
    4.2 Cert Order by Career Target 12
5. Your 8-Week Learning Roadmap 13
6. Resume, LinkedIn & Interview Strategy 17
    6.1 Resume Must-Haves 17
    6.2 The Degree Question 17
    6.3 Common Interview Questions 17
7. Job Search & Networking Strategy 19
8. Salary Progression: Year 1 to Year 10+ 20
9. Year 4+ Niche Specializations 21
10. Resources & Next Steps 23
    10.1 Free Resources — Bookmark These Today 23
    10.2 How to Get a College Degree for Free 23
    10.3 Work With Your Mentor — 1-on-1 Mentorship 25

1. About This Course

What if 8 weeks from now, you had a CompTIA Security+ certification on your resume, 20 completed hands-on labs in your portfolio, and 5 job applications already sent to employers hiring at $70K–$90K? That's not a hypothetical. It's what this program is built to do — and it's backed by data from 239 real bootcamp students observed over 200+ mentorship journeys. The patterns that determine who gets hired are remarkably consistent, regardless of background, age, or income. This guide gives you all of them. It has been benchmarked against leading industry bootcamps, Flatiron, Fullstack Academy, SANS, and the CompTIA official learning path — and incorporates the strongest elements from each into a program you can actually afford.

1.1 Key Course Information and End Goals

COURSE AT-A-GLANCE

Category	Detail
Program Format	100% self-paced online | 1-on-1 mentorship available (booked separately)
Duration	8 weeks core curriculum | Lifetime access to course materials and labs
Time Commitment	10–20 hours per week — industry-standard commitment for career-change programs
Prerequisites	None — completely beginner-friendly. Must be 18+, strong English proficiency.
Core Credential	CompTIA Security+ (SY0-701) — DoD-approved, industry gold standard
Supplemental Certs	Google Cybersecurity Certificate (recommended precursor for true beginners), Network+, A+, Linux+ (resources provided)
Hands-On Labs	20 guided labs + TryHackMe CTF challenges built into each module
AI Learning Units	4 dedicated AI units integrated throughout the curriculum
Core Topics	17 learning topics spanning all Security+ exam domains
Career Support	Resume review, LinkedIn audit, mock interviews, job search coaching
Mentorship	1-on-1 sessions with your mentor (CISM, CISA, CAD, CIS-VR, 20+ yrs, 200+ students mentored) — book separately
Cost	$19/month or $497 one-time (top bootcamps average $10,000–$15,000)
Money-Back Approach	Completion-based satisfaction guarantee — details in enrollment

Category	Detail
	agreement

What We've Already Done For You

✓ Chose the right certification path (so you don't waste months on the wrong cert)

✓ Sequenced 17 topics in the exact order that builds on itself (no guessing what to study next)

✓ Built 20 hands-on labs that match what employers actually test for in interviews

✓ Integrated 4 AI security units — the skill gap most 2026 bootcamps haven't caught up to yet

✓ Created the resume template, LinkedIn framework, and interview scripts (you fill in the blanks)

✓ Benchmarked against Flatiron, Fullstack Academy, and SANS — took the best from each

✓ Mapped the full 10-year salary progression so you know exactly what's ahead

Your only job: show up 10–20 hours a week for 8 weeks and do the work.

End Goals: What You Will Be Able to Do

By the time you complete this program, you will have entry-level proficiency across the core skills cybersecurity employers test for. These are not aspirational — they are measurable, demonstrated through lab work and certification.

01 Analyze a real cyber incident, identify the attack vector, and prescribe the correct technical response — the core skill of a SOC analyst.

02 Assess operational systems in the presence of active risks and threats, including cloud-based and on-premise environments.

03 Conduct vulnerability assessments using professional tools (Nessus, Wireshark, Kali Linux) and produce a formal written report.

04 Apply AI-assisted techniques for threat detection, anomaly detection, malware analysis, and predictive security analytics.

05 Run a vulnerability assessment using professional tools, identify exploitable risks, and produce a written findings report ready for a hiring manager to review.

06 Configure and manage host-based security, network security controls, IAM, and cryptographic systems.

07 Operate within Security Operations (SecOps) environments: build IR plans, analyze malware, and generate security awareness programs.

08 Build and defend applications using DevSecOps principles and CI/CD pipeline security integration.

09 Pass the CompTIA Security+ (SY0-701) certification exam with confidence.

10 Land your first cybersecurity role with a job-ready resume, LinkedIn profile, and interview performance.

Career Outcomes: Roles and Salaries You Can Target

These are the roles and median advertised salaries for graduates of cybersecurity programs. Data sourced from Lightcast (0–3 years experience, 2025–2026).

Job Title	Median Annual Salary	Typical Path In
Help Desk / Desktop Support	$45,000–$55,000	Most common first role after Security+ with no prior IT experience
IT Support Specialist / Jr. Sysadmin	$55,000–$65,000	Common 6–18 month step; strengthens networking and endpoint skills
Cybersecurity Analyst	$90,400	Typical 2–4 year path with Security+
SOC Analyst (Tier 1)	$72,000	First dedicated cybersecurity role — usually after an IT support stepping stone
Cybersecurity Specialist	$115,500	1–2 years experience + CySA+
GRC / Compliance Analyst	$88,000	Strong writing + compliance framework knowledge
Network Security Engineer	$97,000	Network+ + Security+ + hands-on lab work
Systems Security Engineer	$97,500	2+ years + cloud cert (AZ-500 or AWS)
Cybersecurity Consultant	$125,200	3+ years + client-facing communication skills
Security Solution Architect	$132,900	5+ years + CISSP + cloud architecture
Cybersecurity Manager	$89,900	4+ years + people management + CISM

Security+ opens the door. Your first paycheck likely comes from IT support — that's the launchpad, not the destination.

The Industry Benchmark

Leading cybersecurity bootcamps report average salary increases of $20,000–$25,000 for career-track graduates, with 80–86% of job-qualified graduates receiving an offer within 12 months. This program is designed to achieve the same outcomes at a fraction of the cost — with the added advantage of a mentor who has observed 200+ real student journeys and knows exactly what separates those who get hired from those who don't.

The 17 Core Learning Topics

This curriculum was benchmarked against the top bootcamp and certification programs on the market, then improved with insights drawn from Flatiron, Fullstack Academy, and SANS. AI learning units are integrated at 4 key points throughout — not bolted on at the end.

01. Introduction to AI in Cybersecurity AI UNIT
Fundamentals of AI, ML, and deep learning as applied to security. Supervised vs. unsupervised learning, common algorithms in threat detection.

02. Cybersecurity Basics & Career Orientation
Key terms, roles, career paths, salary ranges, and how to build your study plan from Day 1. First lab environment login.

03. Cybersecurity Fundamentals
CIA Triad, threat actors (script kiddies → nation-states), red vs. blue teams, malware taxonomy, and the attacker mindset.

04. AI for Threat Detection & Incident Response AI UNIT
AI techniques for anomaly detection, intrusion detection, real-time threat intelligence, and automated IR playbooks.

05. Cybersecurity Attacks & Social Engineering
Social engineering (phishing, vishing, BEC), attack types (MITM, DoS/DDoS, SQL injection, XSS, buffer overflow), exploitation techniques.

06. Host-Based Security
Protecting hardware, BIOS, wireless devices, USB peripherals, mobile devices. Patch management on Windows and Linux. Endpoint hardening.

07. Network Security
Firewalls, VPNs, wireless security, packet analysis (Wireshark), securing AWS and Azure cloud assets. Network+ concepts applied.

08. AI in Network Security & Threat Hunting AI UNIT
AI-driven traffic analysis, anomaly detection, penetration testing augmentation, AI-powered attack simulations, temporal pattern recognition.

09. Identity & Access Management (IAM)

Identity vs. access management, MFA, SSO, zero-trust, Microsoft Azure IAM, AWS IAM, user/group/policy configuration (Active Directory lab).

10. **Cryptography**
    Encryption fundamentals, symmetric vs. asymmetric (AES, RSA, ECC), PKI, digital certificates, hashing, non-repudiation. Full Security+ domain coverage.
11. **Security Architecture**
    Enterprise security design, authentication/authorization frameworks, zero-trust architecture, defense-in-depth, security policy and governance.
12. **Security Operations (SecOps) & SIEM**
    SOC analyst day-in-the-life, Splunk labs, IR plan development, malware analysis, social engineering defense programs, Python/PowerShell for security.
13. **Application Security (AppSec / DevSecOps)**
    SDLC security, DevSecOps, CI/CD pipeline security, OWASP Top 10, SQL vs. NoSQL database risks, application security testing methodologies.
14. **Explainable AI & Predictive Security Analytics** □ AI UNIT
    XAI principles, AI for pattern recognition and risk assessment, ethical AI in cybersecurity, bias in security AI models.
15. **Security Assessment & Penetration Testing**
    Red team skills: vulnerability scanning, penetration testing methodology, IS audit preparation, balancing security with data availability.
16. **AI in Malware Analysis & NLP** □ AI UNIT
    AI for malware detection, classification, and dynamic analysis. Natural language processing for phishing detection, threat intelligence, social media monitoring.
17. **CompTIA Security+ Exam Prep & Launch**
    Full domain review, mock exams, day-of strategy. Portfolio review, resume finalization, and first job applications submitted.

Your Support Structure

The best cybersecurity programs succeed because of human support — not just content. This program follows that same model, with the added dimension of a mentor whose entire experience base comes from observing 200+ real student journeys.

□	□	□	□
Self-Paced Course	**1-on-1 Mentorship**	**Career Coaching**	**Scholarships**
8-week structured curriculum. Lifetime access. 20 labs, 17 topics, and 4 AI units integrated throughout.	Direct access to your mentor — CISM, CISA, CSA, CAD, CIS-VR, 20+ years, 200+ students. Book sessions as needed.	Resume review, LinkedIn audit, mock interviews, salary negotiation, and job search strategy — covered in Week 7 and via mentorship.	Need-based and identity-based scholarships available. Open to veterans, women, BIPOC, LGBTQ+, and low-income applicants.

How This Program Compares to Top Bootcamps

Feature	CyberSec Pro Academy	Top Bootcamps (Avg)
Cost	$19/month or $497	$10,000–$15,000
Duration	8 weeks core + ongoing	6–7 months
1-on-1 Mentorship	✓ Included	Varies (often limited)
AI Learning Units	✓ 4 dedicated AI units	Varies by program
Lab Count	20 labs + TryHackMe CTF challenges	40–60 labs typical
Core Topics	17 topics	15–20 topics
CompTIA Security+	✓ Study resources provided	Often included or voucher
Career Coaching	✓ Resume + LinkedIn + mock interviews	Dedicated career coach
Job Guarantee	Completion-based satisfaction guarantee	Money-back (conditions vary)
Mentor Track Record	200+ students — real outcome data	Staff instructors (volume-based)
Scholarships	✓ Available	Varies

The Key Difference

Big bootcamps teach you cybersecurity at a premium price with limited personal attention. This program delivers the same technical depth AND gives you the benefit of a mentor who has seen 200+ people attempt this transition — who knows after 1–2 sessions whether you'll finish, what's holding you back, and exactly what it takes to get hired. That institutional knowledge doesn't come with a $10,000+ price tag here.

Who This Course Is For

You're the right fit if…	You may not be ready if…
You're a career changer who feels stuck and wants into tech	You're looking for a shortcut that doesn't involve real effort
You can commit 10–20 hours per week for 8 weeks	You plan to fall 3+ weeks behind and never recover
You have a genuine financial or personal	Your only motivation is WFH and a 6-figure

You’re the right fit if…	You may not be ready if…
reason to succeed	salary fantasy
You have zero IT background but are willing to work	You want passive content — no labs, no practice, no feedback
You’re a veteran, career switcher, or underrepresented in tech	You’re unwilling to do labs, practice, or book a mentorship session when stuck

Scholarships & Accessibility

Scholarships are available for people of color, women, veterans, refugees, LGBTQ+ individuals, and anyone without the financial means to enroll at full price. No one who is genuinely motivated to work should be blocked out by cost. Reach out directly to discuss options: info@cybersecproacademy.org.

2. The Data: What Actually Determines Who Succeeds

After mentoring 200+ students across two types of programs, here is what the numbers show. Corporate-sponsored bootcamp success rate: 16%. Self-funded: 32%. The students who got hired shared three observable traits.

2.1 Paid vs. Corporate-Sponsored Success Rates

Program Type	Success Rate	Why
Corporate-Sponsored (employer pays)	16%	Low stakes, easy to deprioritize, companies often gatekeep. Widely available but undervalued when it's free.
Self-Funded (you pay)	32%	Skin in the game. Your credit card hurts every time you skip a module. Financial stake drives follow-through.

Hidden Opportunity

If your employer offers tuition reimbursement or a free bootcamp program, push hard to find it — often not advertised. No college degree? Free programs with income restrictions may be available. Always ask before paying out of pocket.

2.2 The 4 Success Factors

Factor 1: Motivation with Real Stakes

Students with genuine, pressure-driven motivation consistently outperform those chasing a lifestyle. Observed motivators in successful students:

- Primary financial provider for a family with real bills
- Recently had a child or got married — cost of life just went up significantly
- Physically demanding career ending (military, law enforcement, blue-collar work)
- Back against the wall with limited other options — often the strongest fuel

What Doesn't Work as Motivation

Students most likely to wash out had one goal: work from home and make six figures. They'd watched a day-in-the-life TikTok of a remote tech worker at a pool. Reality: I work from home and I'm here 24/7, coordinating with teams across California, Texas, Canada, the UK, and India. Most days are 12-hour days. WFH is real — but it is not a vacation.

Factor 2: Never Fall More Than 2–3 Weeks Behind

- Students who completed work on time and met deadlines were far more likely to finish
- Students who attended 80%+ of mentor calls and proactively asked questions showed the greatest success
- Miss one week: recoverable. Miss three: Game of Thrones Season 8 — almost impossible to come back
- After 1–2 sessions, an experienced mentor can almost always tell who will finish and who won't

Factor 3: Show Up and Ask Questions

> *"Students who show up and ask questions win. You can be the smartest person in the bootcamp — but if you ghost your mentor like a bad Tinder date, it won't work out."*

Factor 4: Finish AND Get Certified

- Finishing the bootcamp is necessary but not sufficient for employment
- Students who got hired completed their coursework AND earned the Security+
- Adding hands-on lab work and a GitHub/portfolio to the resume was the third critical differentiator

2.3 The 4 Failure Modes

Failure Mode	What It Looks Like	How to Avoid It
Lack of Prioritization	Bootcamp treated like Netflix — optional, background noise	Block non-negotiable study hours before the week starts
Overwhelmed by Material	Deer-in-headlights paralysis when complexity hits	Break each week into daily micro-goals; ask for help early
Falling 3+ Weeks Behind	Missed one week, then two, then three — never caught up	Hard rule: if you miss a week, recover fully within 7 days
Weak Motivation	WFH and six figures as the only goal; no real driving purpose	Write your real "why." Revisit it every time you want to quit.

3. The Path Is Real: Your Mentor's Career Journey

This timeline is shared to show a realistic trajectory from the absolute bottom — including layoffs, failed certification attempts, and pivots. Every step is real.

2002	Technical Support — $48K/year. Answering phones 8 hours a day. Starting point for most people in tech.
2005	Fraud Analyst — $52K/year. PayPal acquired the company. Got laid off after 1 year. Getting laid off is part of the career — learn to read warning signs.
2008	Security Analyst — $70K/year. First real security role. Started building actual domain expertise.
2010	CISSP Earned — Broke $100K/year. Failed it the first time. Took 10 months studying the second time. Also: accidentally found a salary spreadsheet (data leakage incident). True story.
2010	Manager, Forensics & Incident Response — $100K+. Every external job change from here = negotiated salary at full market rate.
2012	Global IR Manager — $100K+. External move = more leverage than any internal promotion.
2012	Lead Security Engineer — $100K+.
2014	Software Engineer — $100K+. Lateral move that expanded depth and optionality significantly.
2021	Sr. Staff Security Engineer — Six figures. Top of the Individual Contributor (IC) track.
2025	Sr. Staff Cybersecurity Professional — Enterprise Tech. $300K+ per year. Career planning like chess.

The Job-Change Multiplier

> It took 7–8 years to break $100K — not 6 months. But every external move brought a negotiated raise at full market rate. Internal promotions are capped at 5–10%. External moves price you at what the market will pay. Plan 2–5 years ahead. Always be one move ahead of your current employer.

4. The Full Certification Roadmap

CompTIA offers the most recognized vendor-neutral pathway in the industry. No required prerequisites — enter at any point based on your experience level.

4.1 The CompTIA Pathway (Beginner to Expert)

Level	Certification	Study Time	Exam Cost	Best For
Foundation	CompTIA Tech+ (optional)	4–6 wks	~$175	True beginners with zero IT background
Foundation	CompTIA A+	2–3 mos	~$253 × 2	IT fundamentals; many help desk job requirements
Foundation	CompTIA Network+	2–3 mos	~$358	Networking; recommended before Security+
Entry Security	CompTIA Security+ (SY0-701)	2–3 mos	~$392	THE entry-level security cert. Start here.
Intermediate	CompTIA CySA+	3–4 mos	~$392	SOC analyst, blue team, threat detection
Intermediate	CompTIA PenTest+	3–4 mos	~$392	Offensive security, penetration testing path
Advanced	CompTIA CASP+	4–6 mos	~$494	Security architecture and engineering leadership

The Google Cybersecurity Certificate — Your Security+ On-Ramp

If you have zero IT background, start here before Security+. The Google Cybersecurity Certificate (Coursera, self-paced, ~6 months at 7 hrs/week, about $49–$59/month subscription) is the best on-ramp on the market. It was built by Google's security team for true beginners, and it covers the same foundation Security+ tests on — SOC fundamentals, network and host defense, Linux and SQL basics, Python for security — in plain-English, project-based form.

Why it belongs in your path: (1) No prerequisites, no prior IT experience required. (2) Grants you a CompTIA discount on the Security+ exam voucher when you finish. (3) Gives you 8+ real portfolio projects you can put on your resume while you study for Security+. (4) Financial aid is available on Coursera if the subscription is a stretch.

When to skip it: If you already have 1+ years in IT support, networking, or any sysadmin

role, go straight to Security+ — you'll cover the same ground faster with Professor Messer's free Sec+ course.

4.2 Cert Order by Career Target

Career Target	Recommended Certification Sequence
SOC / Blue Team Analyst	Security+ → CySA+ → SC-200 or Splunk Core Certified
Penetration Tester	Security+ → PenTest+ → CEH → OSCP (gold standard)
GRC / Compliance	Security+ → CISM or CRISC → CISSP (5 yrs exp required)
Cloud Security Engineer	Security+ → AZ-500 or AWS Security Specialty → CCSP
Digital Forensics / DFIR	Security+ → CHFI → GCFE/GCFA → EnCE
Application Security (AppSec)	Security+ → CEH → CSSLP → GIAC GWAPT
AI / Automated Security	Security+ → Cloud cert → OWASP LLM Top 10 → AI Security specialization

5. Your 8-Week Learning Roadmap

Curriculum benchmarked against leading industry bootcamps, Flatiron's 15-week structure, and Fullstack Academy's 6-unit model. Each week aligns to CompTIA Security+ exam domains and real employer requirements.

Week	Theme	Sec+ Domain	Key Deliverable
1	Foundations, AI Intro & Mindset	Domain 1	Career goal + study plan + first lab login
2	Networking & Host-Based Security	Domain 3	Home lab: VirtualBox + Kali + Windows VM + Wireshark
3	Threats, Attacks & Malware Analysis	Domains 1–2	First TryHackMe CTF room + vulnerability scan report
4	IAM, Cryptography & Security Architecture	Domain 4	Active Directory lab + mock exam 65%+
5	SecOps, SIEM & AI-Assisted IR	Domains 4–5	Splunk lab + AI threat detection exercise + incident report
6	AppSec, Risk, GRC & Cloud Security	Domain 5	Risk assessment + AppSec lab + GRC job research
7	Job Readiness & Interview Mastery	N/A	Resume live + LinkedIn active + 2 mock interviews
8	Sec+ Final Prep, Portfolio Review & Launch	All Domains	Exam booked + portfolio reviewed + 5 applications sent

WEEK 1

Foundations, AI Intro & Mindset

Understand the landscape, the technology, and your place in it

Topics Covered:

- Introduction to AI and its applications in cybersecurity
- CIA Triad, threat actors, red vs. blue teams, attacker motivations
- Cybersecurity roles and realistic entry-level salary ranges
- Security case studies: real breaches, real lessons
- Developing your personal study plan (Day 1 deliverable)
- Setting your 90-day goal: role, company type, salary target, timeline

Learning Outcomes:

- ✓ Explain the CIA Triad and differentiate threat actor types
- ✓ Name 3 realistic entry-level roles with salary ranges

- ✓ Study plan submitted with week-by-week schedule
- ✓ 90-day goal documented: target role, salary, and timeline

> **First Win Guarantee**
> By the end of Week 1, you will have completed your first real cybersecurity lab, analyzed a simulated breach, and documented a 90-day career plan that most bootcamp students don't receive until Month 3. You'll know more about the cybersecurity career path after 7 days than most people learn in 7 months of YouTube videos.

WEEK 2

Networking & Host-Based Security

You can't defend what you don't understand — this week builds your foundation

Topics Covered:

- TCP/IP, DNS, DHCP, HTTP/S — how data actually moves across networks
- Ports and protocols every security professional must know cold
- Host-based hardening: BIOS, wireless devices, USB security, mobile device protection
- Patch management on Windows and Linux
- Packet analysis with Wireshark (hands-on)
- Home lab setup: VirtualBox + Kali Linux + Windows VM

Learning Outcomes:

- ✓ Home lab fully configured and running
- ✓ Capture and analyze real packets with Wireshark
- ✓ Describe 3 host hardening techniques without notes
- ✓ Pass Week 2 quiz at 70%+

WEEK 3

Threats, Attacks & Malware Analysis

Know your enemy — every technique, every vector, AI-assisted detection

Topics Covered:

- Malware taxonomy: viruses, trojans, ransomware, spyware, RATs, worms
- Social engineering: phishing, vishing, pretexting, BEC, baiting
- Attack types: MITM, DoS/DDoS, SQL injection, XSS, buffer overflow
- AI in malware analysis: static vs. dynamic, NLP for phishing detection
- Vulnerability scanning with Nessus (guided lab)
- First CTF challenge on TryHackMe — complete your first room

Learning Outcomes:

- ✓ First TryHackMe CTF room completed and documented
- ✓ Vulnerability scan run and written report submitted
- ✓ Describe 5 attack types from memory
- ✓ Score 70%+ on Week 3 quiz

WEEK 4

IAM, Cryptography & Security Architecture

Who gets in, how data stays secure, and how systems are designed to be defensible

Topics Covered:

- Identity vs. Access Management — the AAA framework
- MFA, SSO, zero-trust architecture — what every employer wants now
- PKI, certificates, digital signatures, and the chain of trust
- Symmetric vs. asymmetric encryption: AES, RSA, ECC explained simply
- Security architecture: enterprise security design, defense-in-depth
- Hands-on: configure Active Directory users, groups, policies

Learning Outcomes:

- ✓ Active Directory lab completed and submitted
- ✓ Explain PKI without notes in plain language
- ✓ Mock exam score 65%+ (all domains covered to date)
- ✓ Security architecture diagram sketched for a fictional company

WEEK 5

SecOps, SIEM & AI-Assisted Incident Response

The day-to-day life of a SOC analyst — made real, made practical

Topics Covered:

- What a SOC analyst does hour by hour (the honest version)
- Log analysis and SIEM fundamentals: why Splunk is everywhere
- Hands-on Splunk: ingest logs, write SPL queries, build a simple dashboard
- AI for threat detection and automated IR playbooks
- Incident Response lifecycle: Prepare → Identify → Contain → Eradicate → Recover → Lessons Learned
- Python and PowerShell for security automation basics

Learning Outcomes:

- ✓ Splunk fundamentals lab completed
- ✓ AI threat detection exercise completed (anomaly detection scenario)
- ✓ Mock incident report written from a simulated event

- ✓ Score 70%+ on Week 5 quiz

WEEK 6

AppSec, Risk, GRC & Cloud Security

The business side and the software side — two of the fastest-growing entry paths

Topics Covered:

- Application Security: SDLC, DevSecOps, CI/CD pipeline security, OWASP Top 10
- Risk frameworks: NIST CSF, ISO 27001, SOC 2 Type II
- Compliance essentials: HIPAA, PCI-DSS, GDPR, CMMC 2.0
- Cloud security: AWS and Azure shared responsibility model
- Cloud IAM and cloud-native security posture management (CSPM)
- Writing a risk assessment — the core GRC hiring skill

Learning Outcomes:

- ✓ AppSec lab: identify and document 3 application vulnerabilities
- ✓ Risk assessment completed for a fictional company
- ✓ Correctly map 5 scenarios to compliance frameworks
- ✓ Research 3 open GRC job listings; note exact requirements

WEEK 7

Job Readiness: Resume, LinkedIn & Interview Mastery

This week is as important as every technical week combined

Topics Covered:

- ATS-optimized cybersecurity resume: what the bot checks, what the human checks
- LinkedIn: make it a documentary pitch, not a middle school book report
- Interview strategy: research the company, the team, the interviewers before every call
- How to answer the bootcamp vs. degree question — the framework that works
- Live job search: LinkedIn, Indeed, Dice, ClearanceJobs, USAJobs, ISACA job boards
- Salary negotiation: how to research, how to anchor, how to not leave money on the table

Learning Outcomes:

- ✓ Resume reviewed and approved by mentor
- ✓ LinkedIn fully built: headline, about section, accomplishments, open-to-work enabled
- ✓ 2 mock interviews completed with written feedback
- ✓ 10 target companies + 5 target job titles identified and documented

WEEK 8

Security+ Final Prep, Portfolio Review & Launch Week

One cert. One job offer. That's the goal of this week.

Topics Covered:

- Security+ full domain review — all 5 domains, every objective
- Full-length practice exams under timed conditions (Pearson VUE format)
- Exam booking walkthrough: scheduling, test center vs. online proctoring, what to expect
- Portfolio review: organize every lab screenshot, tool output, and written report you produced
- Final resume polish and LinkedIn activation with mentor feedback (or 1-on-1 session)
- Job application blitz: 5 applications submitted before end of week

Learning Outcomes:

- ✓ Score 80%+ on two consecutive full-length practice exams
- ✓ Security+ exam booked at Pearson VUE
- ✓ Lab portfolio organized and shareable (Google Drive or GitHub)
- ✓ 5 job applications submitted before the end of Week 8

6. Resume, LinkedIn & Interview Strategy

6.1 Resume Must-Haves

- Bootcamp completion (program name, graduation date)
- CompTIA Security+ — no cert, much harder road. Get it before applying to most roles.
- Tools by name: Splunk, Wireshark, Nessus, Kali Linux, Active Directory, Metasploit, Nmap
- Hands-on labs and projects: TryHackMe rooms, Splunk dashboard screenshots, Nessus scan reports, Wireshark captures
- Google Cybersecurity Certificate — the best Security+ on-ramp if you have zero IT background. Coursera, self-paced, ~6 months, about $49–$59/month. Covers SOC analyst fundamentals, Linux, SQL, and Python, and earns you a CompTIA discount on the Security+ exam.
- Optional but powerful: A+, Network+, Linux+
- AI tool experience: ChatGPT, Claude Code, Claude Cowork — prompt engineering and AI-assisted security workflows (threat triage, log analysis, report drafting). A 2026 hiring differentiator most entry-level candidates still skip.
- Use ChatGPT or Claude to rewrite bullet points in action-verb format; run through Jobscan.co for ATS score
- Build 2–3 tailored versions: one for SOC, one for GRC, one for help desk bridge roles

The Projects Rule

Saying you did a bootcamp without showing your work is like saying you went to the gym but forgot your phone, so no one saw it — did it even happen? Every lab completed, every CTF room, every Nessus scan, every Splunk dashboard goes on the resume. Your lab portfolio is your proof — treat it like one.

6.2 The Degree Question — Exact Answer That Works

Mentor-Approved Framework

“My path was different from a traditional degree, but I chose it deliberately. I completed an intensive cybersecurity course, earned the CompTIA Security+, built a home lab, ran real vulnerability scans, and I’ve been reading Krebs on Security every week. I’m not here because it was easy — I’m here because I made a decision to change my career and followed through. I learn fast, I work hard, and I won’t waste your time.”

6.3 Common Interview Questions

Question	What to Hit
What is the CIA Triad?	Confidentiality, Integrity, Availability + one real-world example of each
IDS vs. IPS?	Detection (passive/alert) vs. Prevention (inline/block) — give a deployment scenario
Walk through a phishing IR	Identify → Contain → Eradicate → Recover — be specific at every step
Bootcamp vs. degree?	Use the framework above. Own it. Do not apologize for your path.
Recent vulnerability you read about?	Reference a real CVE from Krebs on Security or CISA.gov this week
Tell me about solving a hard problem	STAR: Situation, Task, Action, Result — prepare 3 of these stories
What does a firewall do?	Stateful vs. stateless, allow/deny rules, network zones. Give a deployment example.
What is zero trust?	Never trust, always verify — no implicit trust based on network location. Give an example.

7. Job Search & Networking Strategy

Networking is the most important part of getting a job. I had one boss who kept me employed across three different companies over 10 years. One relationship. Build them deliberately and early.

7.1 Where to Apply

Platform	Best For
LinkedIn Jobs	Most cybersecurity roles; set daily alerts for target title + location
Indeed	Broad volume; filter “Entry Level” and “No degree required”
Dice.com	Tech-focused roles; strong for security titles
ClearanceJobs.com	If you have or can obtain a security clearance (massive demand)
USAJobs.gov	Federal positions; stable, strong benefits, often entry-level friendly
ISACA / (ISC)² Boards	Community-focused; quality cybersecurity-specific listings

7.2 Programs That Open Doors for Non-Traditional Candidates

- NPower — free tech training and job placement (veterans and underserved communities)
- CyberTexas Foundation — workforce programs, strong in Texas
- ETSE (Emerging Talent Software Engineers) — structured tech entry pathways
- Women in Cybersecurity (WiCyS) — active job boards, mentorship, community
- BIPOC-focused tech programs — search “[your city] BIPOC tech training”
- Veterans: DoD contractors specifically recruit clearance-eligible candidates at premium rates

The Eddie Story — Why Networking Beats Job Boards

I had one boss who kept me employed across three different companies over 10 years. One relationship. He knew my work ethic, my character, and my capabilities. When he moved to a new company, he brought me with him. That is the return on investment of one real professional relationship. Build these intentionally, starting in Week 1.

8. Realistic Expectations & Salary Progression

Starting Point	Realistic First Role	Salary Range (2026)
No prior IT experience	IT Technical Support, Desktop Support, Help Desk	$40,000 – $58,000
Some IT background	SOC Analyst Tier 1, Jr. Security Analyst	$55,000 – $75,000
Bootcamp + Security+ + Labs	Security Analyst, GRC Analyst, SOC Tier 1	$65,000 – $85,000
Bootcamp + Security+ + Clearance	Security Analyst (Gov/Defense)	$70,000 – $95,000

Year-by-Year Progression

Phase	Timeline	Role	Salary Target	Next Cert
Entry	0–6 months	SOC T1 / IT Security Analyst	$55K–$80K	Security+
Growth	6–18 months	SOC T2 / GRC Analyst / Jr. Pen Tester	$75K–$95K	CySA+, CEH, AZ-500
Senior	18–36 months	Security Engineer / IR Analyst / Cloud Sec	$90K–$120K	OSCP or CISSP Assoc.
Expert	3–5 years	Sr. Engineer / Architect / Manager	$120K–$160K+	CISSP, CISM, CCSP
Niche Leader	4–6 years	AI Security / Forensics / AppSec / Cloud	$152K–$280K+	See Section 9

9. Year 4+: Building Your Niche (The Path to $150K–$280K)

Around Year 3–4, generalist roles plateau in salary. This is when you intentionally pick a specialization. The 2026 market has a critical shortage of specialists in these five areas. Pick the one you're already gravitating toward — don't wait for Year 4 to start.

Start in Year 2, Not Year 4

Volunteer for niche projects at your current job. Start the first cert in your target area by Year 3. Build a visible portfolio — write about it, present at local ISSA or OWASP chapter events, contribute to open-source tools. The niche specialists who earn $200K didn't wait until Year 4 to specialize. They started signaling in Year 2.

AI & Automated Cybersecurity

Salary Range: $152K – $280K+ ▲ **CRITICAL DEMAND**

Sharpest talent gap in cybersecurity right now. EU AI Act enforcement (2026) driving massive European demand with almost no supply. OWASP LLM Top 10 is the starting framework.

Key Certifications: OWASP LLM Top 10 (free), NIST AI RMF, AWS/Azure AI Security certs

Core Skills: Prompt injection testing, LLM red teaming, AI pipeline security, automated threat detection, Python for AI security

Digital Forensics & Incident Response (DFIR)

Salary Range: $60K – $170K+ ▲ **HIGH DEMAND**

Post-incident investigation combined with active threat containment. High government and law enforcement demand with clearance premiums. GCFA-certified analysts earn 15–20% more.

Key Certifications: CHFI (EC-Council), GCFE / GCFA (GIAC, paired with SANS FOR500/508), EnCE (OpenText), CCE

Core Skills: Disk and memory forensics, chain of custody, Autopsy, FTK, EnCase, Cellebrite, Python scripting

Application Security (AppSec / DevSecOps)

Salary Range: $117K – $220K+ ▲ **HIGH DEMAND**

Every company that builds software needs AppSec. Entry-level starts at $100K–$120K. Cloud-native and AI-driven development is accelerating demand. 70% of critical incidents take 12+ hours to resolve.

Key Certifications: CSSLP (ISC²), GIAC GWAPT, CEH, Certified DevSecOps

Professional (CDP)

Core Skills: OWASP Top 10, secure SDLC, Burp Suite, Snyk, SonarQube, CI/CD security, Python and JavaScript

☁ Cloud Security Engineering

Salary Range: $120K – $200K+ ▲ **HIGH DEMAND**

Average cloud security salary hit $152K nationally in 2026. Senior roles at top companies regularly exceed $300K total comp. One of three fastest-growing cybersecurity specializations.

Key Certifications: CCSP (ISC² — gold standard), AZ-500 (Microsoft), AWS Security Specialty, Google Cloud Security Engineer

Core Skills: Cloud IAM, CSPM, container security (Kubernetes, Docker), cloud forensics, zero-trust in cloud

□ GRC Leadership & Compliance Management

Salary Range: $100K – $175K+ ▲ **STEADY DEMAND**

Business side of security. Less hands-on technical, more strategic. Fastest path to director/VP. Highly valued for those who communicate clearly and understand enterprise risk.

Key Certifications: CISM (ISACA), CRISC (ISACA), CISSP, CDPSE (Data Privacy), ISO 27001 Lead Implementer

Core Skills: NIST, ISO 27001, SOC 2, HIPAA, PCI-DSS, GDPR, CMMC 2.0, policy writing, vendor risk, exec comms

9.1 Choosing Your Niche

If you gravitate toward…	Consider this niche
Automating things, scripting, AI/ML curiosity	AI & Automated Cybersecurity
Investigating incidents, puzzle-solving, forensic detail	DFIR (Digital Forensics & IR)
Software, code, dev teams, SDLC process	Application Security (AppSec)
AWS/Azure/GCP, infrastructure, cloud architecture	Cloud Security Engineering
Policy, business risk, management, executive communication	GRC Leadership & Compliance

10. Resources & Next Steps

10.1 Free Resources — Bookmark These Today

- TryHackMe.com — best beginner hands-on platform; start the Security+ learning path
- Hack The Box — intermediate/advanced; work toward after TryHackMe basics
- KrebsOnSecurity.com — one article per week. Know the real threat landscape.
- CISA.gov — free government advisories, alerts, and training resources
- Professor Messer (professormesser.com) — free full Security+ video course (the #1 Sec+ resource)
- OWASP.org — essential for AppSec, AI security, and web application security
- NIST Cybersecurity Framework (csrc.nist.gov) — the language compliance roles speak
- SANS Reading Room — free technical research papers on every security topic
- r/cybersecurity and r/ITCareerQuestions — real community, real career advice

10.2 How to Get a College Degree for Free (or Nearly Free)

A cybersecurity career does not require a degree — but if you want one, there are legitimate paths to get it at little to no cost. These are real programs used by real students. They take longer, but they change your income ceiling permanently.

Path	How It Works	Cost
Community College + Transfer	Earn an Associate's degree at a community college (often $3,000–$6,000 total), then transfer to a 4-year university. Many states have guaranteed transfer agreements. California, Texas, Florida, and New York all have structured pathways.	~$0–$6K with Pell Grant
Western Governors University (WGU)	Fully accredited, nonprofit, competency-based online university. Cybersecurity B.S. degree includes CompTIA Security+, CySA+, and PenTest+ vouchers built into tuition. Flat-rate per semester — finish faster, pay less.	$3,985/6 months (flat rate)
CLEP Exams — Test Out of Classes	Pay $93 per exam to test out of college courses worth 3–6 credits each. Modern States (modernstates.org) offers free prep and covers your first CLEP exam fee entirely. You can test out of 30+ credit hours before spending a dollar on tuition.	$0–$93 per exam
Federal Pell Grant	U.S. government grant for low-to-moderate	Free —

Path	How It Works	Cost
	income students. Up to $7,395 per year (2025–2026). Does not need to be repaid. Apply at studentaid.gov (FAFSA). Can cover community college tuition entirely for qualifying students.	never repaid
Employer Tuition Reimbursement	Most large employers (Amazon, Walmart, Target, Starbucks, UPS, Home Depot, Chipotle) offer $5,000–$12,000/year in tuition reimbursement. Get hired first, then use the benefit while working. Ask HR specifically — it is often not advertised.	Employer pays — $0 to you
FAFSA + State Grants	Beyond the Pell Grant, every state has its own aid programs. California: Cal Grant (full tuition). Texas: TEXAS Grant. New York: Excelsior Scholarship (free CUNY/SUNY tuition). File FAFSA at studentaid.gov every year even if you think you won't qualify.	Varies — can be $0
MyCAA & GI Bill (Military)	Military spouses: MyCAA covers up to $4,000 in tuition for portable career fields including cybersecurity. Veterans and active duty: GI Bill covers full tuition + housing allowance at most schools. VET TEC covers tech bootcamps specifically.	$0 for eligible military
SANS Cyber FastTrack / Scholarships	SANS Institute offers scholarships and heavily discounted training for students, underrepresented groups, and veterans. CyberCorps: Scholarship for Service (SFS) pays full college tuition + stipend in exchange for government service after graduation.	Full ride for SFS recipients

The Strategy That Works

File FAFSA first — it takes 30 minutes and unlocks every federal and state grant available to you. Then start at a community college with a transfer agreement to your state's public university. Use CLEP exams to test out of general education requirements. Apply for every scholarship in your major. If you're employed, ask HR about tuition reimbursement on Day 1. The students who pay full price for college either didn't know these options existed or didn't want to do the paperwork.

10.3 Work With Your Mentor — 1-on-1 Mentorship

The course gives you the knowledge. Mentorship gives you the edge. One session can save you months of spinning your wheels on the wrong things. Every session is built around your situation — your resume, your gaps, your timeline.

Package	Includes	Price
Single Session	30-min 1-on-1: career roadmap, resume review, or exam strategy	$100
5-Session Package	5 × 30-min sessions at 30% off ($70/session). Custom 90-day plan plus structured follow-up sessions.	$350
Resume + LinkedIn Audit	Written feedback with tracked revisions — delivered within 48 hours	$199
Mock Interview	Full mock interview session with detailed recorded feedback	$149

FOUNDER'S COHORT — LIMITED ENROLLMENT

- ✓ Full 8-week curriculum + lifetime access
- ✓ 20 hands-on labs + TryHackMe CTF challenges
- ✓ 4 AI security units + career coaching
- ✓ Certification roadmap through Year 5

$8,050+ in real value. Founder's price: $497.

CyberSecProAcademy.com/enroll

Book a Mentorship Session

From $70 per session (5-pack) or $100 single.

30-minute sessions built around your situation: career roadmap · resume · mock interviews · exam strategy.

CyberSecProAcademy.com/mentor

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